

Chapter 32-1

Haizhou City¹ rarely had good weather in autumn. The sun hung high, the sky was bright and clear, with occasional white clouds floating in the azure sky, scattered by the warm, gentle breeze.

A large group of people stood under the canopy. Li Ran was instructing the cameraman to keep the footage good and make sure to capture Zhao Ying beautifully.

The photographer was a fan of Zhao Ying and sheepishly scratched the back of his head with a laugh, "Our Yingying is so beautiful, she looks gorgeous no matter how we film her."

Zhao Ying's assistant stood by with a water cup waiting, while other artists' areas were equally bustling.

The staff were busy coordinating while trembling with fear about how to deal with the angry director.

But Zhao Ying casually pointed toward Liang Shi's direction and suggested letting her act.

The originally noisy film crew suddenly felt like someone had pressed the pause button, as everyone looked over in unison.

But there were too many people under the canopy.

For a moment, they couldn't tell which person Zhao Ying was pointing at, but after everyone scanned the people inside, they immediately understood.

Probably only that face could make Zhao Ying personally nominate someone.

Despite wearing only a simple, plain business suit—an apricot-pink blazer paired with loose wide-leg pants and five-centimeter light-colored heels, with her hair casually tied in a ponytail—it couldn't conceal her outstanding temperament at all.

Tall enough, elegant enough, and beautiful enough.

Even when she stood there unsmiling, appearing cold and unapproachable, she seemed more commanding than Chen Liuying, the so-called "Nation's Number One Dominant Alpha."

That face was a landmark in itself.

The director obviously noticed too and inquired, "Who is that?"

"Someone from BARE here for an interview," Zhao Ying said. "As long as she's pretty enough, what does it matter where she's from?"

Director: "..."

"She doesn't know how to act," the director frowned. "We can't just pull any random person onto set, right?"

"As if Lu Ci² knows how to act," Zhao Ying mercilessly mocked the actress who had stood them up.
"With that silicone face, what can she do besides blinking and showing cleavage? I could pull a dog from the street and it would have more spirit than her."

Director: "..."

The director wavered.

He didn't really want to agree, but looking at that face, it was really hard to refuse.

"Why don't you ask?" the director said. "See if she's willing to act?"

"She was just staring at us acting with her eyes practically popping out," Zhao Ying said. "Director, your people-reading skills aren't great."

Director: "...?"

He had just been busy explaining the scene!

Zhao Ying waved at Liang Shi, "Little sister, come over here."

Liang Shi: "?"

Although she had just made eye contact with Zhao Ying, she didn't dare assume 100% that Zhao Ying was calling her.

She pointed at her own nose, "Me?"

Zhao Ying nodded, "Yes, the prettiest one."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her foot, which had already stepped forward, retracted halfway.

"Yes, you," Zhao Ying said again. "Why are you so lacking in confidence?"

Liang Shi: "..."

What did this have to do with confidence?

With a hundred and eighty people on set, when you say "the prettiest one," what if it wasn't her?
How embarrassing would that be?

Zhao Ying's assistant nudged Liang Shi's arm, "Go on, Sister Ying is calling you."

Liang Shi glanced at Li Ran, who gave her a thumbs up and whispered, "Seize the opportunity."

Having received Li Ran's approval, Liang Shi walked over.

"Little sister, want to act?" Zhao Ying was much more outgoing than Zhao Xuning. She proactively introduced, "A villain role. I think you're quite suitable."

"Yingying, are you kidding me?" the director said. "With this kind of temperament playing a villain, it's not convincing at all. Let's find someone else."

"Didn't you just think she was quite suitable?" Zhao Ying raised an eyebrow, bold and unrestrained. "Beautiful people should play villains—that's what makes it compelling, playing that kind of character people love and hate at the same time."

After Zhao Ying finished speaking, she paused and suddenly looked at Liang Shi again, "But this little sister, I always feel like I've seen you somewhere before."

"Any pretty girl, you feel like you've met before," the director teased from the side.

Zhao Ying shrugged, "Can't help it, I'm attracted to beauty."

They stood there discussing enthusiastically, but the director still felt uneasy and asked Liang Shi, "Have you acted before?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Yes, I have. I'm a veteran actor.

She kept a straight face and deceived her heart: "No experience."

The original body's past "glorious achievements" were all known to Zhao Xuning, and as her cousin, Zhao Ying could find out everything with just one inquiry. She still had to keep it hidden.

"Well then..." the director hesitated. "I should contact Wang Qiang instead. She's at a nearby film crew, I can have her come over for a cameo."

"Wang Qiang with that innocent look can only play idol drama female leads. Put her in a suit and she looks like a child wearing adult clothes. What kind of villain could she play? And you want to ask Director Wang for someone? What are you thinking?" Zhao Ying scoffed lightly. "I think this little sister is quite suitable. She looks like she has the aura of someone who can act."

Liang Shi: "..."

The director was still hesitating. Zhao Ying gave him a shot of confidence: "When have I ever been wrong about people?"

"Fine. Let's go with her," the director said. "Let's try first."

"I object." Chen Liuying, who had just gone to take a phone call, returned to find the situation had changed to this.

It was already annoying enough to see Xu Qingzhu's wife here, and now the director wanted her to act? And opposite her, no less. This was too ridiculous.

"Liuying." The director explained the situation to her, then persuaded, "Let her try first, otherwise you won't be able to wrap up today either."

"Are you threatening me?" Chen Liuying frowned. "I only have two scenes left, but you can't find someone like this to act opposite me, can you? Are you looking down on me or trying to ruin the entire drama? She's never acted a day in her life, isn't from a professional background—what could she possibly act?"

"Anyway, she's only doing two scenes with you, the rest are all with me." Zhao Ying glanced at her sideways. "If she can act with me, why can't she act with you? Meaning she's worthy of me but not you?"

Chen Liuying was left speechless.

In the entertainment industry, this kind of place where the strong prey on the weak and seniority matters, Zhao Ying had debuted earlier than her and was stronger than her. Wherever they met, she had to respectfully call her "Sister Ying."

Moreover, she was a socialite with the Zhao family backing her.

Someone of Chen Liuying's grassroots background couldn't compare.

She immediately apologized, "Sister Ying, that's not what I meant."

"Then what did you mean?" Zhao Ying scoffed lightly. "If you think she can't act, then have the screenwriter delete your two scenes, or find a body double. Just don't delay your wrap-up."

"Sister Ying." Chen Liuying explained, "I think having a random person who doesn't understand the industry act is disrespectful to drama."

"Using you would be respectful?" Zhao Ying rolled her eyes. "May I ask which school you graduated from? Are you professionally trained? What was your ranking?"

Chen Liuying: "..."

"My teacher is..." Chen Liuying hadn't finished speaking when she was interrupted. Bai Weiwei came running over and immediately apologized: "Sorry Teacher Zhao, Liuying is just considering the crew's interests, thinking using a newcomer who's never acted isn't appropriate. She didn't mean to offend you."

"Why did you come over directly?" Chen Liuying looked at her with an unfriendly tone. "Didn't I tell you to wait in the car?"

Bai Weiwei tugged at her and apologized to Zhao Ying again, "Teacher Zhao, I'm sorry. Liuying is still new to the entertainment industry and doesn't understand. Please don't take it to heart."

"She's already an adult, how much longer does she plan to not understand? Learn virtue before learning art. Some people, if their art isn't refined, should at least have good character. A person can't be lacking in both areas, right?" Zhao Ying had already started mocking, her arrogant face clearly expressing—this old lady just looks down on people like you who don't understand anything but still pretend everywhere.

Bai Weiwei could only apologize, "Sorry Teacher Zhao, Liuying only has two scenes left. We'll act them out properly."

"Whatever," Zhao Ying said. "If you don't want to act, just delete and modify the scenes. It's not like you're doing this for the first time."

Bai Weiwei: "..."

Bai Weiwei felt hurt inside but still smiled on her face.

Footnotes:

¹ Haizhou City: The fictional city where the story takes place

² Lu Ci: The actress who stood up the film crew

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Zhao Ying suddenly pushed Liang Shi forward, "Director, give us a word—are you using this little sister or not? If not, let her go. Is she supposed to stand here watching actresses tear each other's hair out?"

Director: "..."

He looked at Liang Shi's face, steeled his heart, and said, "We'll use her."

Bai Weiwei also looked toward the newcomer. Originally, she had wanted to say a few polite words to let the other party act well with Chen Liuying, but when she saw it was Liang Shi, her constantly smiling face fell.

"Hi," Liang Shi greeted her. "Are you feeling better?"

Bai Weiwei clenched her fists and said through gritted teeth, "I'm fine."

"That's good," Liang Shi said.

"Props manager," the director called. "Give the script to the newcomer."

Then he hesitantly asked, "Can you understand the script?"

Liang Shi nodded, "I can."

Zhao Ying pulled her over, "I'll teach you anything you don't understand."

Liang Shi: "..."

The director was vaguely worried but had no choice.

The people on set had already exploded into chaos, similarly divided into two camps.

Some thought randomly pulling people onto set to act was like playing around, and this time Zhao Ying had really gone too far, obviously slapping Chen Liuying in the face.

But others thought that person's face was beautiful, so her acting probably wouldn't be too bad.

"Who said that? Look at Chen Liuying—pretty face, right? She traded her acting skills for it. If it weren't for Sister Ying carrying her, she'd NG twenty times a day," a small crew member said.

"Sister Ying has indeed been fed up with her for a long time, but who told her she has a good agent? Damn, her agent is rich and pulls resources for her, and still has to bow and scrape to apologize for her. If I had this kind of agent, I'd be famous too."

"You don't have that fate. What bullshit 'Nation's Number One Dominant Alpha'—just a gold digger eating soft rice."

"But aren't we discussing the newcomer? Can she really act? That role would be really outstanding if performed well."

"Probably can't. She's been smiling cheerfully since she arrived—doesn't have that aura."

"That's what makes the contrast big! Look at Sister Ying, usually she's the cool sister type, but last time she played an innocent high school student—so amazing!"

"How many years has Sister Ying been acting? She's someone who's been acting since she was in the womb. Can a newcomer compare?"

"..."

Everyone sympathetically looked at the newcomer, probably about to be mocked by Chen Liuying during their scene together.

Meanwhile, Chen Liuying pulled Bai Weiwei aside, first blaming her for coming, then scolding her for undermining her as soon as she arrived—why did she bow and scrape to apologize to Zhao Ying?

Bai Weiwei also felt wronged, "Didn't I instruct you? Don't get into disputes with Zhao Ying. She's not someone we can provoke. If you really make her angry, you'll be blacklisted tomorrow."

"Let me be blacklisted then. Can't I just quit this industry?" Chen Liuying scoffed. "I've had enough of these days of playing the grandson."

"But you..."

Before Bai Weiwei could finish, Chen Liuying said, "You saw it too—that's Liang Shi. What drama can a waste like her act in?"

Bai Weiwei glanced toward the other side of the set. Zhao Ying was sitting there drinking tea, while Liang Shi had moved over a small stool and sat there reading the script, looking quite serious.

"She's just pretending," Chen Liuying said. "This kind of person, clearly born with everything, still wants to come to other fields for a piece of the pie. Wouldn't it be better to just be a good young lady?"

"Anyway, her acting is bad," Bai Weiwei let out a light sigh. "You don't need to worry about her, just act well."

"But she's going to slap me later," Chen Liuying said. "Other actors can control their strength, but what if she really hits me?"

Bai Weiwei: "..."

Bai Weiwei had just gotten out of the hospital and come over, and now she had a headache from all this noise.

But she couldn't not care, so she could only console Chen Liuying, "It's fine. Her bad acting will just highlight yours, right? Besides, everyone has eyes—when she acts, she'll definitely be laughed at."

Chen Liuying's restless heart was slightly soothed.

Bai Weiwei said through gritted teeth, "What kind of waves can that waste stir up?"

Chen Liuying sneered coldly, "I'm just waiting to see her make a fool of herself."

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Liang Shi hadn't expected the opportunity to come so suddenly.

After getting the script, she still felt like she was standing on clouds, her steps unsteady.

Originally, she had planned to wait until she got her own body back before going to the film studios to look for opportunities, but now the opportunity had directly hit her on the head.

"Read it quickly," Zhao Ying said. "Time is tight and the task is heavy. Ask me if there's anything you don't understand. I need to do an interview first."

Liang Shi: "..."

What a time management master.

"Okay," Liang Shi said. "Thank you, Sister Ying."

"It's nothing big," Zhao Ying said, then paused and stared at her face with a frown. "But I really think you look familiar. Have we met somewhere before?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She coughed lightly and leaned over to whisper, "Sister Ying, I'm called Liang Shi, and then... I'm sort of good friends with Zhao Xuning... I guess."

The second half of the sentence sounded guilty no matter how she said it.

But Zhao Ying remembered, "Zhao Xuning's friend? No way, the last time I saw you two, you seemed to be fighting."

"I was wondering why you looked so familiar," Zhao Ying said. "You're the third daughter of the Liang family?"

"Right," Liang Shi answered while marking her lines in the script. "That's me."

Zhao Ying looked at her meaningfully, then said with a slightly sarcastic tone after a moment, "I don't think I was wrong about you. You can act this role true to character."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Yes.

This role was a villain, and the kind of malicious supporting female character who slaps people.

"But you look different from before," Zhao Ying asked. "Can you really act it well?"

Liang Shi didn't give a definitive answer, only saying, "I'll try."

Footnotes:

None for this chapter.

Chapter 32-3

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The two scenes Liang Shi was acting with Chen Liuying were Chen Liuying's wrap scenes.

One required splashing water on Chen Liuying, and another required slapping Chen Liuying.

Perhaps Zhao Ying was right about one thing—if it were the original body, she really could have acted true to character.

Liang Shi also hadn't acted for some time.

In her previous world, due to online rumors, various film crews had terminated their contracts with her. After transmigrating, she hadn't even touched a script.

Even so, seeing the script still made her blood boil with excitement.

Soon, she grasped the story and became familiar with the character she was about to play.

It was an overbearing female executive who bullied newcomers by relying on her high position, driving away the second female lead played by Chen Liuying and insulting her character.

Quite similar to Editor-in-Chief Sun.

Besides a few scenes with Chen Liuying, she also had several scenes opposite Zhao Ying, though all of them involved being crushed by Zhao Ying's commanding presence.

So this character was indeed not simple.

Early on, she was arrogant and domineering, but later became miserable and pitiful.

But if acted well, it would be very outstanding.

Liang Shi had never challenged this type of image before. She didn't have the mindset of wanting to convince Chen Liuying or prove her abilities—she simply wanted to stand in front of the camera and give this character a deeper soul.

After reading the script, she began memorizing her lines, just like memorizing texts.

Zhao Ying was surprised, "You read it that fast?"

"Mm," Liang Shi said. "There aren't many scenes, so I read quickly."

"Alright, but you have quite a few lines. It doesn't matter if your acting is poor, at least memorize your lines well," Zhao Ying instructed.

Liang Shi wanted to use the restroom, so she jogged there still holding the script.

In the restroom, she could hear the crew members discussing her.

"That person is really lucky, being personally nominated by Sister Ying to act."

"If you were as pretty as her, you'd have that kind of luck too. Those legs, that face—I'm really in love."

"Do you think she's an Alpha or Omega? I can't tell."

"With that height, she should be an Alpha, right?"

"Could also be a Beta. But I mainly think it'll be interesting when she acts opposite Chen Liuying later."

"Chen Liuying has been trained by Sister Ying for months. Her acting should at least be better than a street dog. But the newcomer... her acting skills are worrying."

"What a waste of that face."

"..."

They quickly washed their hands and left, and only then did Liang Shi push open the stall door.

She felt her luck was really too good—every time she was in a restroom, she could overhear various things.

Liang Shi rolled up the script and stuffed it in her suit pocket. The pocket was already shallow, and she could barely fit it in. After washing her hands, she took it out.

A few seconds later, Chen Liuying emerged from a stall.

Liang Shi: "..."

What a narrow road for enemies.

However, Liang Shi didn't strike up a conversation with her. They weren't on the same path and weren't familiar, so she just quietly washed her hands. But when Chen Liuying came over, she squeezed Liang Shi to one side, causing her script to fall to the ground.

Liang Shi frowned, "What are you doing?"

"Sorry about that," Chen Liuying didn't even look at her and said coldly, "Didn't see you."

Liang Shi turned off the faucet. Not wanting to cause trouble here, she bent down to pick up the script, but Chen Liuying stepped on it.

After a moment, she lifted her foot and looked down at the script on the ground, "Tsk, sorry, I didn't see it."

Liang Shi looked at the footprint on the script. There had been water stains on the ground originally, and Chen Liuying's foot was also wet. Now large water stains had seeped into the paper, blurring some of the words.

Although Liang Shi had a good temper, she wasn't a soft persimmon to be kneaded by anyone. She looked up with an unfriendly tone, "Are you blind?"

Chen Liuying: "...I already apologized. What more do you want?"

"Then how about I kill you and apologize to your corpse afterward?" Liang Shi scoffed lightly. "With such a small capacity for tolerance, what are you doing in the entertainment industry?"

Chen Liuying: "..."

"You haven't even entered the entertainment industry yet, and you're already talking big," Chen Liuying sneered. "Taking yourself way too seriously."

"What's it to you?" Liang Shi countered.

She picked up the script and shook off the water, splashing droplets onto Chen Liuying.

"What are you doing?" Chen Liuying said, "Are you crazy?"

"Since you know I'm crazy, don't provoke me," Liang Shi looked down at her with disdain, being slightly taller. "Even if you don't know what I was like before, Bai Weiwei knows. So don't try to bully a crazy person, understand?"

Chen Liuying was startled, then scoffed, "Just a waste who's never acted in a single scene, really thinking you're some big shot?"

Liang Shi stared straight at her.

"If it weren't for your connection with Zhao Xuning, would Zhao Ying have chosen you?" Chen Liuying sneered. "Just a nepotism hire."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow, "So what? If it weren't for Bai Weiwei packaging you and using her connections to pave your way, would you have what you have today?"

Fearing this wasn't painful enough, Liang Shi paused and added, "Just someone eating soft rice the hard way¹."

This hit Chen Liuying's sore spot, and she immediately swore, raising her fist toward Liang Shi, "You fucking—!"

Liang Shi easily blocked it—her strength was no match for Liang Shi's.

Liang Shi looked at her with a cold smile, "If you want others to respect you, you need to do something worthy of respect first."

"You!" Chen Liuying glared at her angrily.

Liang Shi pushed down the arm that was forcefully exerting pressure, "As for whether I can act, let's wait and see."

Chen Liuying's wrist ached dully.

After Liang Shi came out, she encountered Bai Weiwei. The two kept some distance, and she didn't go forward to greet her, only nodded from afar before leaving.

Footnotes:

¹ "Eating soft rice the hard way" (软饭硬吃): A Chinese idiom referring to someone who relies on others (especially romantic partners) for financial support while pretending to be independent or putting on airs.

Chapter 32-4

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With time being tight and the task heavy, the director only gave Liang Shi half an hour, then briefly watched her run through scenes with Zhao Ying. Finding that she recited her lines clearly, which passed as acceptable, he had someone take her for makeup and hair.

Modern drama styling was easy to handle, and with Liang Shi's good foundation, it was done in less than ten minutes.

Since cameras tend to wash out makeup, they applied an extra layer of foundation, making her one shade paler than before.

While Liang Shi had previously worn light-colored lipstick, to highlight her villainous temperament, they applied red 999¹ series lipstick—bright red with full commanding presence—and changed her suit to black.

Black suit with white shirt, an extremely striking contrast.

When her styling was complete, the director privately said to Zhao Ying, "Regardless of how her acting is, once made up, her compatibility with the character is quite high."

"Let's wait and see," Zhao Ying said. "Treating a dead horse as if it were alive²."

She first filmed the two scenes with Chen Liuying. Before official filming began, the two had to rehearse together, but Chen Liuying's performance was uncooperative.

During rehearsal, she recited her lines lazily, completely different from Liang Shi's performance. Liang Shi read her lines without much emotion, like loudly reading a text aloud, but she articulated every word very clearly.

The director asked Chen Liuying to put more effort in, but Chen Liuying scoffed, "Why don't you tell her that? She's reciting like reading a textbook—what passion can I have?"

"You're the senior, lead her a bit," the director said. "Have you forgotten how Zhao Ying guided you? Acting can be led."

Chen Liuying didn't argue back, "Oh."

Although she agreed, it was just superficial compliance.

The director was furious inside, silently repeating eight hundred times that he'd be a pig if he ever used internet celebrities again!

Every one of them—poor acting skills but big attitudes.

However, he wasn't completely confident in Liang Shi either, so he could only comfort her, "Just try your best, don't put too much pressure on yourself."

"Okay, thank you, Director," Liang Shi politely thanked him.

They first filmed the water-splashing scene. Because a junior employee brought the wrong document, the female executive angrily grabbed a cup of water and splashed it, soaking the employee's shirt completely, followed by a long speech requiring imposing momentum.

Worried that Liang Shi couldn't handle it, the director initially didn't put water in the cup, saying they'd try once after cameras rolled.

He hadn't hoped for a single take anyway—getting something decent after ten takes would be worth thanking heaven for.

As filming approached, everyone on set actually became nervous too, whispering discussions.

"Can she really do it? The newcomer's line reading isn't even as good as Lu Ci's."

"Not even as good as Chen Liuying when she first started acting."

"I think the newcomer is about to get crushed by Chen Liuying."

"As a senior, crushing a newcomer is pretty normal, right? What's worth bragging about?"

"Given Chen Liuying's temper, the newcomer will probably get scolded to death."

"Lighting a candle for her."

"..."

A small assistant asked Zhao Ying, "Sister Ying, can she really do it?"

"I don't know," Zhao Ying answered honestly. "That face is indeed suited for cameras."

Small assistant: "..."

The director sat behind the camera, also feeling somewhat apprehensive, but having mentally prepared himself fully, he had the script supervisor get ready to begin.

The sound recording and cameras were all ready on set.

In the distance was an endless grassland, with Liang Shi sitting under the canopy to cool off.

Soon, Chen Liuying entered the frame, "President Qian³, here's the information you requested."

Liang Shi took off her sunglasses, glanced casually, pinched a corner of the document with two fingers, looked at her, and delivered her first line: "Which department are you from?"

Chen Liuying: "Marketing department."

Liang Shi smiled contemptuously, looked down at the document, but as she read, her brow furrowed. She directly threw the document at Chen Liuying, "You can't even get the simplest document right—what are you doing at work?"

"No, President Qian, this is exactly what you asked for..."

"You dare talk back?"

Liang Shi raised a cup of water and splashed it over.

...

Liang Shi hadn't acted for a long time, so facing the camera again made her slightly nervous, preventing her from displaying all her acting skills.

But even this little bit was enough.

When acting opposite Chen Liuying, she didn't lose ground at all, even managing to portray that arrogant and domineering energy, especially in her eye acting.

The director was quite shocked. After she finished this scene, he called cut, then applauded continuously, and had the crew touch up her makeup while props filled the cup with water.

The director picked up his megaphone and shouted loudly, "Liang Shi, just maintain this state and act well—strive for one take! Liuying, your attitude was a bit too firm just now, soften it more, be more pitiful. Alright, after we adjust, we'll officially film one take."

Having had one practice run, Liang Shi had grasped the feeling.

After throwing the papers at Chen Liuying, they scattered like heavenly flowers, A4 sheets floating everywhere. "Is this how you do your job? Three years in the company and you still get documents wrong!"

...

This scene made everyone clench their fists, especially when Chen Liuying silently crouched down to pick up the documents and Liang Shi stepped on them again.

Her high heel ruthlessly punctured through the paper.

Liang Shi frowned and said, "Useless waste who can't do anything deserves a miserable life."

She delivered this line to the camera, with proper intonation and emotion, lowering her voice as if speaking to each person in front of the screen—the sense of immersion was too strong.

After she lifted her foot, she took tissues to wipe her hands, methodically.

The tissue wiped across her slender fingers, and in the camera, she was a complete beautiful and crazed villain.

...

Not sure who started applauding first, but then thunderous applause erupted on set.

"Holy shit, the newcomer's acting is this strong?"

"I'm totally immersed—a beautiful crazy villain is the most compelling!"

"My god! Who said the newcomer can't act?! She'll be Best Actress at next year's Magnolia Awards!"

"I thought Chen Liuying's acting could crush the newcomer, but she got crushed by the newcomer instead."

"Worthy of being someone chosen by Sister Ying—really too strong!"

"..."

Their scattered discussions also reached Liang Shi's ears, and she finally breathed a sigh of relief.

Fortunately, all those years of effort weren't wasted.

Those days and nights of practicing lines in front of mirrors to shape characters well, those screenwriting books read to understand scripts and characters, those days of running around on film sets.

All the sweat and tears shed on this path were accumulation.

She first looked toward Zhao Ying, who gave her a thumbs up.

Footnotes:

¹ Red 999: A reference to a popular bright red lipstick shade, often associated with bold, confident looks

² Treating a dead horse as if it were alive: Chinese idiom meaning to try everything possible even when the situation seems hopeless

³ President Qian: The character name for the role Liang Shi is playing (Qian is a surname)

Chapter 32-5

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The slapping scene with Chen Liuying afterward was supposed to be staged, but each time Chen Liuying couldn't deliver the effect the director wanted.

So after six NGs¹, Liang Shi didn't consult with Chen Liuying and directly slapped Chen Liuying across the face with a crisp sound, stunning Chen Liuying completely.

But Liang Shi immediately continued with her own performance. Her lines were fluent, her emotions full, each line delivered with indignation. After insulting her opponent, she even revealed a cold smile with a hint of malice that made people's hair stand on end.

After finishing the scene, the director praised, "Liang Shi, I never expected you to be such a good acting prospect."

Liang Shi modestly replied, "Not at all, it was just some improvisation."

"Now that's being modest," Zhao Ying said lightly from the side, but with a hint of stirring up trouble. "Your improvisation is already this good—what are those who've been acting for months but still got outperformed by you supposed to think? They'll cry."

Liang Shi: "..."

She glanced at Chen Liuying.

Chen Liuying covered the half of her face that had been slapped, "Liang Shi, you did that on purpose."

"To help you wrap up early," Liang Shi said calmly. "I did my best."

Chen Liuying: "..."

"Alright, it's all for the sake of the performance," the director mediated, taking the flowers handed over by the props team. "Congratulations Liuying, happy wrap!"

Chen Liuying was furious but couldn't make a scene.

After all, she still had to work in this industry.

However, on the car ride back to the hotel after finishing her scenes, she cursed in front of Bai Weiwei, "What kind of thing is that! Really thinks she can act now? Isn't it just because the character suits her? Young mistress being arrogant and domineering—she probably does this kind of thing all the time! Actually slapping me, so vicious."

"It didn't leave any marks," Bai Weiwei was a bit tired. "Consider it a sacrifice for art."

"But we agreed it would be staged," Chen Liuying said. "She just doesn't like us. That time you took Xu Qingzhu to Huayue International², she's been waiting to get revenge!"

"Chen Liuying!" Bai Weiwei scolded angrily. "We agreed not to bring that up."

Chen Liuying suddenly paused, shrinking into her seat with a cold laugh, "You treat her like a best friend, but does she treat you like one? What has she done besides encouraging you to break up? You really are a naive girl."

Bai Weiwei pressed her throbbing temples, "Zhu doesn't even know Liang Shi went out to act."

"So what if she knew? She'd probably be happy that her wife slapped your girlfriend," Chen Liuying said sarcastically. "Hasn't it been like this since school? She's always been better than you at everything. You think her wife is trash, but maybe she thinks you found yourself an actor."

"Zhu isn't that kind of person," Bai Weiwei said. "Stop talking."

"Heh, you never really know someone," Chen Liuying shrugged. "Anyway, think about it yourself—how come she gets Liang Shi to take the role while you get Zhao Xuning?"

"I said stop bringing this up," Bai Weiwei glared at her. "Are you done?"

"I'm just trying to remind you that no matter how trashy Liang Shi is, she's still Xu Qingzhu's wife. They're unified from beginning to end," Chen Liuying said. "Only a naive girl like you wouldn't protect your girlfriend. You let someone slap her and still think they're innocent."

Bai Weiwei turned her face away, not looking at her.

Footnotes:

¹ NG: "No Good" - film industry term for a take that needs to be redone

² Huayue International: A location mentioned earlier in the story, likely an entertainment venue

Chapter 32-6

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Liang Shi and Zhao Ying's scenes were in the afternoon.

Lunch was crew box lunches, and this crew's food wasn't bad—three dishes and a soup.

Liang Shi rarely came to film sets, so she was happy and took a photo of the box lunch to post on her social media.

Then not long after, Zhao Xuning commented: [This is that pig slop from the crew?]

Liang Shi: ...

Liang Shi: Well said, please don't say it again next time.

When she switched back to the chat interface, she found that Zhao Xuning had sent her a screenshot.

The contact was labeled as Zhao Ying, who had also posted on social media—the same box lunch with the caption: Even pigs wouldn't eat this.

Liang Shi: "..."

She actually thought it tasted pretty good.

But she tentatively asked Zhao Xuning, [Can you give me your cousin's WeChat?]

Zhao Xuning: [Aren't you together?]

Liang Shi: [Too many people on set, asking for WeChat would look like I'm hitting on her.]

Zhao Xuning: [...]

Liang Shi: [After all, I have a wife, I need to stay faithful.]

Zhao Xuning: [...?]

After a while, someone actively added Liang Shi as a friend.

The profile picture was identical to the one in Zhao Xuning's screenshot.

Liang Shi immediately accepted and sent a well-behaved emoji, [Hello, Sister Ying.]

Zhao Ying: [Hello there, act well this afternoon.]

Liang Shi: [I will!]

After adding Zhao Ying on WeChat, she received another new message—a transfer from Liang Xinhe for 200,000 yuan.

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Xinhe: [Our family isn't so poor that we'd make you eat pig slop.]

Liang Shi: [Second Brother, the crew lunch is pretty good.]

Liang Xinhe: [...Just looking at it kills my appetite.]

Liang Shi sent six dots.

She didn't understand the world of the wealthy.

She was used to staying on film sets. Although she could normally have good food, on sets it was basically like this.

Some actors did make special demands, but Liang Shi never did—she always ate the same box lunches as the extras.

Box lunches weren't about taste—they were about efficiency. Eat quickly, rest, and be ready for the next scene.

If you wanted good food and sleep, there weren't such conditions.

However, Liang Shi didn't transfer the 200,000 back. She kept it in her account for future emergencies, or to return to Liang Xinhe when he needed it.

The afternoon shoot was with Zhao Ying.

When researching Zhao Ying before, Liang Shi had found that Zhao Ying was famously obsessed with acting—everything served the performance.

She had played courtesans and generals, housewives and career women, high school students and other people's mothers. So Zhao Ying had an excellent reputation in the industry.

Moreover, her acting was superb, and there weren't many people in the industry who could match her performance.

Liang Shi was also nervous before filming, but Zhao Ying said, "Little sister, don't be afraid, I'll hold back a bit."

She was being very considerate.

But Liang Shi smiled and said, "Sister Ying, let's try once first. You should still use your full strength to act, and I'll see how I need to adjust."

Along with nervousness came anticipation.

She had watched Zhao Ying's cuts online, and every segment had strong emotional impact. She was very much looking forward to what it would feel like to act opposite such a person.

In Liang Shi's previous entertainment industry, her acting was also considered quite good, but she was young after all and still needed the tempering of years.

However, she was already a typical example of natural talent.

Acting opposite Zhao Ying now, she indeed couldn't keep up the first time.

But by the second time, she had gradually found her rhythm.

By the third time, she could match Zhao Ying evenly, though there were still differences in subtle details.

For good actors, a tiny difference could mean a world of difference.

On the third take, this shot was completed.

In the following scenes, Liang Shi had already adapted to Zhao Ying's acting rhythm, keeping up with her pace, and almost every scene was completed in one take.

This stunned everyone present.

Crew members couldn't help but whisper, "I remember the last actress of similar age who could act opposite Sister Ying like this was Yang Shuyan¹."

"This is incredible, more exciting than watching edited clips on video sites."

"When this airs, it'll be explosive."

"I've heard of natural talent, but I've never seen someone being force-fed by heaven itself."

"I can only say there are differences between people."

"Both were guided by Sister Ying, but Chen Liuying is still the same after four months, while this one can act opposite Sister Ying after less than half a day."

"I'm really impressed. I want to see them in a period drama about enemies-to-lovers, dual female leads playing villains."

"I already have the image in my head."

"Add Yang Shuyan too—the kind you'd click to watch just from one look."

"..."

Everyone was discussing enthusiastically, but Liang Shi just felt exhilarated.

Acting opposite someone like Zhao Ying, a method actor, was a joyful thing.

Even though she still had shortcomings, it was thoroughly satisfying.

Zhao Ying felt the same.

After the director called cut, Zhao Ying took several minutes to come out of character. Once she did, she said to Liang Shi, "Little sister, next time I have work, I'll call you."

Liang Shi: "..."

She smiled and readily agreed, "Deal!"

Footnotes:

¹ Yang Shuyan: A fictional actress name mentioned as a comparison point for skilled acting

Chapter 32-7

//

On the way back to the company, Li Ran and the cameraman looked at Liang Shi differently, with a hint of admiration.

The cameraman couldn't help but ask, "Liang Shi, how did it feel acting with my goddess?"

"Very comfortable," Liang Shi said. "Sister Ying's acting is excellent."

"Of course, my goddess swept all the major awards with just one drama. The year she became famous in the entertainment industry, people jokingly called it 'the purple star descending from heaven¹,'" the cameraman said proudly. "But you actually held your own acting opposite my goddess, not losing in presence at all. You don't seem like someone acting for the first time."

Liang Shi just smiled without giving a direct answer.

After returning, Li Ran went to submit the article.

Liang Shi returned to her workstation and left on time.

After work, she drove to Rainbow's kindergarten, which was an international bilingual kindergarten where only the wealthy sent their children.

Kindergartens dismissed early, and the entrance was deserted with no one around.

She made a wasted trip, but still used the number Rainbow had given her to call Teacher Qi Jiao.

The phone was quickly answered, and Liang Shi inquired, "Hello, is this Teacher Qi?"

"Yes," the other party's voice was gentle. "You are?"

"It's like this, I'm a colleague of Zhou Caihong's mother," Liang Shi said. "I'd like to verify something with you. I'm currently at the entrance of the kindergarten where you work. Do you have time?"

The other party was silent for a moment, "Alright, please wait, I'll come out right away."

"You haven't left work yet?" Liang Shi was surprised.

"Still organizing files in the archive room," Qi Jiao said. "Please wait."

"Okay, take your time."

Liang Shi didn't wait long at the kindergarten entrance before seeing Qi Jiao. She wore a white dress, had very pale skin—the unhealthy kind of pale—with shoulder-length hair. She was extremely thin, about the same as Xu Qingzhu, and looked very gentle.

Liang Shi greeted her and introduced herself first, "Hello, I'm Liang Shi."

Upon hearing this name, Qi Jiao suddenly froze. Her hands hanging at her sides unconsciously clenched into fists, and she subconsciously swallowed, taking half a step back.

Liang Shi looked at her puzzledly, her hand still suspended in the air, "Is something wrong?"

Qi Jiao immediately shook her head, "No... nothing."

Then she reached out to shake hands, separating immediately.

"Did you know me before?" Liang Shi asked.

Qi Jiao shook her head, stammering, "No... I don't know you."

Liang Shi found it strange, but she hadn't come today to get to know Qi Jiao. She mainly wanted to clarify the bracelet matter. She extended her arm, "Teacher Qi, Rainbow said you once confiscated a bracelet like this. Could you see if it's the same one?"

Qi Jiao looked down and after a while said, "Yes, a child in our class brought one before. I confiscated it once, then later gave it to her parents."

Throughout, Qi Jiao maintained distance from her, and her eyes were full of wariness and vigilance.

"Could you tell me which child it was?" Liang Shi asked. "And who her parents are?"

"Because this bracelet is very important to me, I really want to find the owner of this bracelet, so I hope you can tell me," Liang Shi said very sincerely.

Qi Jiao shook her head, "Sorry, this is the children's privacy, I can't say."

Liang Shi asked again, "I know it was little Su Yu. Could you tell me who her parents are? Or just tell me who her mother is," Liang Shi said. "I just want to confirm."

She somewhat suspected Su Yu was Su Yao's daughter, but had no evidence.

Moreover, there had been no news about Su Yao online for a long time, and Su Yao wasn't even present at those international competitions.

"Ah, this..." Qi Jiao hesitated, then still said firmly, "Sorry, our kindergarten has rules that parent information is confidential."

Having reached this point, Liang Shi was too embarrassed to press further.

However, she asked, "Is Su Yu's mother named Su Yao?"

Qi Jiao was silent for a moment, then still gave her a small favor by shaking her head.

"I understand, thank you, Teacher," Liang Shi said. "You go back to your work."

Qi Jiao watched her departing figure and let out a heavy breath.

She felt like her heart was about to jump out of her chest.

Was she Liang Shi?

The Liang Shi written about in the diary.

Qi Jiao covered her pounding heart and ran all the way back to the office.

After closing the office door, a teasing voice rang out, "What's wrong? You're so scared?"

"Nothing," Qi Jiao said. "Someone asked about student parent information."

"Did you tell them?" A beautiful Alpha woman asked, smoothly embracing Qi Jiao from behind, her hands moving improperly from waist to chest, "Our upright little Teacher Qi?"

When she said "little Teacher Qi," she carried a hint of ambiguity, making the Omega in her arms tremble. The small hands grasped the Alpha's improper hands, pleading in a low voice, "Cheng Ran, not here."

Cheng Ran chuckled softly, leaning close to her ear and whispering, "But little Teacher Qi, what if I want to do it here?"

As she spoke, she extended her tongue tip, gently sweeping across the Omega's earlobe, making the Omega blush completely. "Did you miss me while I was abroad?"

Qi Jiao bit her lip, afraid that seductive sounds would escape her mouth, but the mischievous Cheng Ran pinched her buttocks, "Tell the truth, Teacher Qi."

Qi Jiao's eyes filled with physiological tears from her actions. Now Cheng Ran had her sitting on the office desk, looking at her pitifully while weakly pushing her away, "Cheng Ran, please not here, okay?"

"Not okay," Cheng Ran said as she moved to kiss her. "I want to do some love—"

She drew out the sound, making it extremely ambiguous, and whispered the remaining words in her ear, "—making with our little Teacher Qi in her workplace."

Footnotes:

¹ Purple star descending from heaven: A Chinese idiom referring to the arrival of an exceptionally talented person, particularly in the arts or literature

Chapter 32-8

//

Liang Shi returned empty-handed, but felt that Teacher Qi's behavior was somewhat strange.

But it could also be explained as being afraid of strangers.

That evening, Xu Qingzhu still came home very late.

Liang Shi waited for her to return before going to her room.

Occasionally when Liang Shi woke up in the early morning hours, she would impulsively go to the living room and discover the study light was still on, with Xu Qingzhu still staying up late working on proposals.

There wasn't much she could help with, so she would heat up a cup of milk and bring it over.

One night when she went in, Xu Qingzhu was looking at design drafts.

She was clearly exhausted beyond measure, her eyelids drooping, but she propped up her eyelids with both hands as she sat there looking, the whole person drowsy.

The sound of Liang Shi pushing the door startled Xu Qingzhu. She immediately sat up straight, but couldn't help yawning, "You're not asleep yet?"

"I already had a full night's sleep and woke up," Liang Shi said. "You can't keep working overtime like this forever."

"Everyone in our department is working overtime," Xu Qingzhu's voice was muffled as she made a fist and gently knocked her head, putting her glasses back on to look at the design drafts. "I can't make special exceptions."

"You could take it slowly," Liang Shi said. "If you exhaust your body like this, there won't be anyone who can step up when the time comes."

"The autumn fashion show is about to begin," Xu Qingzhu said. "Every day now is a countdown for me. There's simply no possibility of rest."

Liang Shi: "..."

Seeing Xu Qingzhu constantly knocking her head, she asked, "Do you have a headache?"

"From staying up too much," Xu Qingzhu said. "A little."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow, "Should I massage it for you?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and looked up at her. She was standing in a backlit position, wearing blue silk pajamas—long sleeves and long pants—with her long hair casually loose on both sides of her shoulders. Her face was gentle, and her gaze was also very tender.

As if struck by softness.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, "That would trouble you."

"No problem," Liang Shi walked behind her and reached out to press on her temples, deliberately avoiding looking at her computer screen.

Xu Qingzhu's slender fingers clicked on the mouse, and soon she was typing content in a notebook document. After a while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Would you like to help me look at this sample design?"

Liang Shi was surprised, "Can I look at it?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...Now you can."

Design drafts, especially those before new product launches, were all classified internal company materials.

Once leaked, they could potentially have a huge impact on a company.

So Xu Qingzhu had been slightly cautious before, but the biggest problem was that day when she came in, she was on a call with Sally and didn't really want Liang Shi to hear.

Actually, letting Liang Shi look at the design drafts was fine, since Dongheng Group had invested a lot of money.

They were grasshoppers on the same rope¹.

The sample designs on screen had been 3D processed, so they weren't difficult to look at.

"What should I look for?" Liang Shi asked.

"Find flaws," Xu Qingzhu said. "This is a design Lin Luoxi created. She never sees problems with her own work, but she has high standards for herself and asked me to tell her at least three flaws tomorrow. And I think this looks weird too, Sally also thinks it's weird, but we can't say what's weird about it."

Because this design draft was indeed stunning at first glance.

But then it would seem increasingly strange the more you looked at it.

Liang Shi was surprised when she first saw it. It used autumn's high concept, integrating starry sky and cosmic elements, taking already overused elements and presenting them anew, with every detail executed to perfection. It was a bold style with very innovative design.

But she had the same feeling as Xu Qingzhu—stunning at first glance, then feeling somewhat off.

"Is this just one image?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and scrolled down, "This is an autumn series, twenty-four images total, but this is the basic model. The rest are all modifications based on this one."

Liang Shi nodded, "Scroll down."

Xu Qingzhu was distracted and didn't hear, "What?"

A thought flashed through Liang Shi's mind, but she hadn't accurately captured it yet. In her urgency, she directly reached out to grasp the mouse.

Xu Qingzhu's hand was on the mouse.

Liang Shi's hand was slightly larger than Xu Qingzhu's, covering it perfectly.

Her gaze was fixed intently on the screen as she pressed the mouse and scrolled down.

She looked at each image for no more than three seconds, and after browsing all the images, she returned to the first image and suddenly said with certainty, "I know what the problem is."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze had originally been on her hand, but upon hearing this, she immediately asked, "Where?"

"Look at this, her color is sky blue, leaning toward deep blue tones, which doesn't match most people's wearing habits. And this inner ring design, although it's studded with stars, there are too many of them, making it look very complex, like this one." Liang Shi flipped to the twenty-third image, "This one is just right, the perfect degree."

"Also, aren't you going for autumn's high concept? This image's design looks more like spring, using colors that are too green. Better to change it to fallen leaf yellow, that light orange color."

"..."

Liang Shi spoke eloquently at the desk, pouring out all her opinions. Xu Qingzhu listened carefully, following her train of thought to analyze, and finally understood.

She smiled, "That's right."

"We've been looking at drafts so much recently that we can't spot problems at all," Xu Qingzhu said. "Sometimes the problems are actually quite obvious."

"I just happened to stumble upon it like a blind cat catching a dead mouse²," Liang Shi said modestly. "Hurry up and write this, finish writing and go to sleep. You'll definitely be drowsy at work tomorrow."

"There's coffee," Xu Qingzhu said. "Which office worker doesn't stay up late?"

"But I've never seen anyone who stays up as intensely as you," Liang Shi said. "Let me drive you to work tomorrow, you can sleep a bit in the car."

Xu Qingzhu paused, originally wanting to refuse but the words that came out were, "Okay, thank you."

"Then hurry up and write," Liang Shi said. "I won't disturb you anymore."

"Mm," Xu Qingzhu responded quietly, but didn't start writing. Liang Shi asked, "Why aren't you writing?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze moved from Liang Shi's chin all the way to her right hand, seeing that her hand was still covering Xu Qingzhu's hand.

Liang Shi was startled and immediately pulled back her hand, stammering, "I, I, I, I... I didn't mean to."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Seeing her like this, Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but laugh, "It's fine."

Liang Shi's ears turned red, "I'm going out now."

"Go ahead, sleep early," Xu Qingzhu said.

But before Liang Shi left, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said, "Liang Shi, are you free this Friday evening?"

"Yes," Liang Shi said. "What's up?"

"I have a friend returning from abroad who wants to meet you. When we got married, she didn't know, so she wants me to bring you to apologize to her," Xu Qingzhu said this with a wandering gaze, unsure if Liang Shi would agree.

The main thing was that Sally's additional condition for returning to help was to meet her wife.

Sally had just returned and been dragged by her to help at the company, not even adjusting to the time difference before directly helping her start working on design drafts.

Lin Luoxi also hadn't slept for several nights.

They were both quite concerned about her married life, so they strongly requested she bring her wife out for a meal together, or come to their house.

Xu Qingzhu felt it was better to meet outside. If they came to her house, she'd have to share a room with Liang Shi again.

Worried that Liang Shi might agree without knowing anything, Xu Qingzhu added, "She has a really high alcohol tolerance."

"My alcohol tolerance isn't bad either," Liang Shi immediately said. "No problem. Should I book a private room? Your company is pretty busy lately, right?"

"I'll book it," Xu Qingzhu said. "I know what they like to eat. You just need to come directly when the time comes."

"Okay."

Footnotes:

¹ Grasshoppers on the same rope: Chinese idiom meaning people who share the same fate or are in the same situation

² Blind cat catching a dead mouse: Chinese idiom meaning to succeed by luck rather than skill

Chapter 32-9

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The next morning, Liang Shi drove Xu Qingzhu to work. She had also made simple sandwiches for Xu Qingzhu to eat in the car before resting.

Additionally, since she got up early, she made two lunch boxes for noon.

One for herself and one for Xu Qingzhu to take.

She drove Xu Qingzhu to the company building before returning to her own company.

This scene happened to be witnessed by Sally, who walked over holding an iced Americano, "Blanche, we're here working overtime until we cry, while you're being sweet with your wife. We're so miserable."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"I just saw your wife," Sally said. "She looks pretty good. How about it? Did you tell her about dinner? Does she have time? If not, we can go to your place. I haven't found a house yet and I'm staying at a hotel. If it weren't for considering you two are newlyweds, I would have moved in long ago."

Staying up all night drawing designs didn't interfere with Sally's chatterbox nature—she chirped like a little sparrow in her ear.

Xu Qingzhu immediately said, "I already told her. This Friday evening, I'm treating."

"Why are you treating? OMG." Sally made an exaggerated surprised expression. "If you're treating, why call her? As your friend, shouldn't she be treating? Haven't you ever treated her friends?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...Actually, no."

However, Xu Qingzhu didn't argue about this issue and directly shifted the topic to work, "Last night I found the problem with Cherry's design draft. Quickly eat some breakfast, let's have a meeting."

Only then did she remember, "Where's Cherry?"

"She went home to shower," Sally said. "That clean freak—she'll die if she doesn't shower twice a day."

Xu Qingzhu: "...No wonder you two can't live together."

Sally: "..."

Sally was someone who could go two days without showering, but Lin Luoxi, as a severe germaphobe, had to shower twice a day.

"So you know how painful it was when we were together, right?" Sally held her forehead. "I can't even bear to recall it."

Lin Luoxi's voice rang out coolly from the doorway, "How truly wronged you were."

Sally: "..."

//

Friday evening, Xu Qingzhu booked dinner at a Chinese restaurant.

Because Sally truly loved Chinese cuisine. Once in college during a game of truth or dare, while she was drunk, Lin Luoxi asked her: "If you had to leave China one day, what would you miss most?"

Without thinking, Sally blurted out, "Soup dumplings¹."

This nearly made Lin Luoxi want to bite her to death.

Afterward, Sally seriously explained to Lin Luoxi, "I really feel sorry for every foreign compatriot who hasn't eaten Chinese food. They've really missed out on too many good things."

During her years studying in China, Sally had almost checked off cuisines from all regions, and whenever she talked about them, she could recite them like family treasures.

The three of them came together after work. When they arrived, Liang Shi was already sitting at the table waiting. Upon seeing Xu Qingzhu, she stood up, looking at her with a smile full of affection in her eyes.

"Wow," Sally exclaimed. "Blanche, your wife is really beautiful."

"Our Zhu isn't bad either, okay?" Lin Luoxi immediately said. "Put away that infatuated face."

"Yes, I think my wife is more beautiful," Liang Shi said.

"Let me introduce everyone," Xu Qingzhu interrupted their conversation and made introductions for both sides. Sally was talkative and, although meeting for the first time, wasn't shy at all.

Lin Luoxi had met Liang Shi at the wedding before, but the impression hadn't been good then.

After they all sat down, Liang Shi poured tea for everyone, her movements unhurried and graceful in every step.

Sally could pick up on any topic she chatted about.

To converse with Liang Shi, Sally kept speaking in her broken Chinese until she couldn't say something and anxiously blurted out a sentence in English, which Liang Shi immediately answered in English.

Sally was delighted, "Your English pronunciation sounds so good. Are you really not a singer? I think you must sing well."

Liang Shi smiled and answered, "Does a wild singer who hasn't released any albums count as a singer?"

"Then we can go to KTV later," Sally extended an invitation.

Liang Shi didn't refuse.

Lin Luoxi, observing from the side, looked at all this with confusion, then whispered to Xu Qingzhu, "Is this your wife-controlling magic? Why is she completely different from four months ago?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

What did this have to do with her?

She wanted to know too!

"What's different?" Xu Qingzhu wanted to get some answers from others.

"Her eyes," Lin Luoxi had seen countless people—her mother was an excellent diplomat, so she was very good at reading people. "Four months ago, there was no light in her eyes at all, and she seemed very fake. My god, I was wondering then why you would fall for someone like that. She was completely superficial²."

Xu Qingzhu: "...And now?"

Lin Luoxi took a sip of tea and said leisurely, "Like tea—the more you taste it, the more flavorful it becomes. She gives a very comfortable feeling."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

In the evening, Sally insisted on drinking with Liang Shi. Liang Shi said her alcohol tolerance wasn't bad, so Xu Qingzhu believed her.

But unexpectedly, after three glasses of wine, Liang Shi's face turned red.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Why did she believe Liang Shi at that time?

However, she still loyally accompanied Sally in drinking. After drinking, they went to KTV, where Liang Shi's singing was indeed very good.

Not only was her English pronunciation very standard, but her Cantonese³ pronunciation was also very standard.

When it was time to leave, Lin Luoxi supported Sally, who could barely stand, while Xu Qingzhu supported the drunk but quiet and obedient Liang Shi.

On the way back, Liang Shi was very quiet throughout, completely unlike someone who would usually cause trouble for Xu Qingzhu when drunk.

It wasn't until they got home that Liang Shi opened her eyes. But those eyes were hazy, and she smiled at Xu Qingzhu, saying very gently, "You're so beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu felt her ears heat up, then helped her into the room, threw her onto the bed, and went to pour her a glass of water.

When she returned, Liang Shi was lying on the bed giggling foolishly.

Xu Qingzhu asked her, "Who are you?"

"Liang Shi," Liang Shi's voice carried a hazy drunkenness. "Don't you remember me?"

She sat up with an obedient posture, like a five-year-old child.

Xu Qingzhu touched her head and coaxed, "I remember."

"Where were you from originally?" Xu Qingzhu asked again, with a hint of coaxing.

"Originally..." Liang Shi repeated, then frowned. "Originally... where was I from originally?"

She sighed, her voice very aggrieved, "Sister, I can't remember."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She gave up and said, "Then just go to sleep."

"Okay," Liang Shi said in a very cute childish voice. "I'm going to sleep now. You should sleep well too."

"Mm-hmm, okay," Xu Qingzhu said perfunctorily, wanting to help her drink water, but Liang Shi didn't cooperate and instead smiled brilliantly.

She said, "Life will definitely get better, because we will definitely have lots of love."

Xu Qingzhu's water glass suddenly fell to the ground, and she was completely stunned.

Footnotes:

¹ Soup dumplings: Xiaolongbao (小笼包), a type of steamed dumpling filled with broth

² Superficial: Literally "embroidered pillow" (绣花枕头), a Chinese idiom meaning something that looks good on the outside but lacks substance

³ Cantonese: A Chinese dialect spoken primarily in Hong Kong and Guangdong province